

Life's Highest Blessings

Maṅgala Sutta (Sn 2.4 / Kp 5)

Evam me sutam— ekam samayaṃ bhagavā sāvatthiyaṃ viharati jetavane
anāthapiṇḍikassa ārāme. Atha kho aññatarā devatā abhikkantāya rattiya
abhikkantavaṇṇā kevalakappaṃ jetavanaṃ obhāsetvā yena bhagavā
tenupasaṅkami; upasaṅkamitvā bhagavantaṃ abhivādetvā ekamantaṃ aṭṭhāsi.
Ekamantaṃ ṭhitā kho sā devatā bhagavantaṃ gāthāya ajjhabhāsi—

Thus have I heard— At one time the Blessed One was staying in Sāvatthī, in the Jeta Grove, in Anāthapiṇḍika's monastery. Then a certain deity, when the night was far spent, of surpassing beauty, lighting up the entire Jeta Grove, approached the Blessed One. Having approached and paid respects to the Blessed One, she stood to one side. Standing to one side, that deity addressed the Blessed One in verse:

“Bahū devā manussā ca, maṅgalāni acintayum; Ākaṅkhamānā sotthānaṃ, brūhi
maṅgalamuttamaṃ”.

"Many deities and human beings have pondered over blessings, desiring safety: Declare, Sir, the highest blessing."

“Asevanā ca bālānaṃ, paṇḍitānañca sevanā; Pūjā ca pūjaneyyānaṃ, etaṃ
maṅgalamuttamaṃ.

"Not to associate with fools, to associate with the wise, and to honor those worthy of honor: This is the highest blessing.

Patirūpadesavāso ca, pubbe ca katapuññatā; Attasammāpaṇidhi ca, etaṃ
maṅgalamuttamaṃ.

To reside in a congenial locality, to have made merit in the past, and to direct oneself rightly: This is the highest blessing.

Bāhusaccañca sippañca, vinayo ca susikkhito; Subhāsītā ca yā vācā, etaṃ
maṅgalamuttamaṃ.

Ample learning and proficiency in crafts, being well-trained in moral discipline, and words that are well-spoken: This is the highest blessing.

Mātāpituupaṭṭhānaṃ, puttadārassa saṅgaho; Anākulā ca kammantā, etaṃ
maṅgalamuttamaṃ.

Supporting one's mother and father, cherishing one's wife and children, and work that is
unconflicting: This is the highest blessing.

Dānañca dhammacariyā ca, ñātakānañca saṅgaho; Anavajjāni kammāni, etaṃ
maṅgalamuttamaṃ.

Generosity and living by the Dhamma, supporting one's relatives, and actions that are
blameless: This is the highest blessing.

Āratī viratī pāpā, majjapānā ca saṃyamo; Appamādo ca dhammesu, etaṃ
maṅgalamuttamaṃ.

Avoiding and abstaining from evil, refraining from intoxicating drinks, and diligence in virtues:
This is the highest blessing.

Gāravo ca nivāto ca, santuṭṭhi ca kataññutā; Kālena dhammassavanaṃ, etaṃ
maṅgalamuttamaṃ.

Reverence and humility, contentment and gratitude, and hearing the Dhamma at the proper
time: This is the highest blessing.

Khantī ca sovacassatā, samaṇānañca dassanaṃ; Kālena dhammasākacchā, etaṃ
maṅgalamuttamaṃ.

Patience and obedience, seeing monks and holy seekers, and discussing the Dhamma at the
proper time: This is the highest blessing.

Tapo ca brahmacariyañca, ariyasaccāna dassanaṃ; Nibbānasacchikiriyaṃ ca, etaṃ
maṅgalamuttamaṃ.

Self-restraint and a holy life, seeing the Noble Truths, and the realization of Nibbāna: This is the
highest blessing.

Phuṭṭhassa lokadhammehi, cittaṃ yassa na kampati; Asokaṃ virajaṃ khemaṃ,
etaṃ maṅgalamuttamaṃ.

Although touched by worldly conditions, one's mind is unshaken, free from sorrow, stainless,
and secure: This is the highest blessing.

Etādisāni katvāna, Sabbattha maparājītā; Sabbattha sotthiṃ gacchanti, Taṃ tesarī
maṅgalamuttaman”ti.

Having fulfilled these things, they are everywhere unvanquished, and everywhere they go in
safety: This is their highest blessing."

Glossary

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
maṅgala	maṅgala	blessing; auspicious sign	Life's Highest Blessings	Redefined by the Buddha from superstitious omens to practical, moral actions that generate safety and happiness.
vinaya	vinaya	discipline; moral training	Life's Highest Blessings	In lay life, referring to moral restraint and code of ethics (<i>sīla</i>) that protects one from unwholesome actions.
dhammacariya	dhammacariya	living by the Dhamma	Life's Highest Blessings	Living in accordance with natural law, maintaining morality and awareness of impermanence.
appamāda	appamāda	diligence; heedfulness	Life's Highest Blessings	The critical quality of persistent, alert

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				awareness to avoid falling back into unwholesome reactive mental habits.
santuṭṭhi	santuṭṭhi	contentment	Life's Highest Blessings	Inner peace and satisfaction with what one has, preventing the fire of craving (<i>taṇhā</i>) from growing.
brahmacariya	brahmacariya	chaste life; holy life	Life's Highest Blessings	A pure life, free from sensual defilements, focusing entirely on spiritual development.
lokadhamma	lokadhamma	worldly conditions	Life's Highest Blessings	The eight worldly winds: gain and loss, honor and dishonor, praise and blame, pleasure and pain.
nibbāna	nibbāna	liberation; extinguishing	Life's Highest Blessings	The ultimate goal: the complete eradication of craving, aversion, and ignorance, resulting in peace.

Translator Notes

1. **Redefinition of Auspiciousness (*Maṅgala*):** The sutta systematically shifts the contemporary Indian search for external omens (like rat-bites or shapes seen at dawn) to internal actions. Each "blessing" is a step in moral and meditative development.
2. **Lay and Monastic Path:** The blessings start with basic social relations (associating with the wise, supporting parents, blameless livelihood) and end with higher spiritual achievements (seeing Noble Truths, realizing Nibbāna, and remaining unshaken by worldly winds), showing the path is a gradual training (*anupubba-sikkhā*).
3. **Worldly Winds (*Lokadhamma*):** In verse 11, *lokadhammehi* refers to the eight worldly conditions. The state of an unshaken mind (*cittam yassa na kampati*) is the definition of true equanimity (*upekkhā*), the peak of Vipassana practice.